



Lethal upgrade: For Roger Federer, the one-handed backhand may have been a chink in his armour against opponents such as Rafael Nadal, but after switching to a wider racket in the final phase of his career, the shot was transformed into an almost unstoppable weapon.

The subsequent years were not kind to the Austrian.

A persistent right wrist injury forced him to retire early in 2024 when he was just 31, leaving him to watch from afar something so dear to him slowly vanish from the sport.

"It's a very special shot for me and I loved playing it. It brings something unique to the game, and I would love to see future generations continue playing it," Thiem added.

The long decline

There are at least two reasons why the shot is so revered. First, its elegance is arguably unmatched. Few shots in tennis have captivated audiences quite like the one-handed backhand.

Second, some of the personalities who wielded it left an indelible mark on the sport. Rod Laver and Billie Jean King were early trailblazers. Pete Sampras, Boris Becker and John McEnroe used it to rewrite history,

while Stan Wawrinka, Richard Gasquet, Dominic Thiem and, especially, Roger Federer carried the mantle forward with effortless grace.

For Federer, the one-handed backhand was a chink in his armour, particularly against Rafael Nadal's topspin forehand. Yet it remained a delight to watch.

Rohan Bopanna, a two-time Grand Slam doubles champion who also used a one-handed backhand, believes several factors have led to its decline.

"I think the biggest factor is how much more high-voltage the game has become. Players are hitting with more pace and spin, especially off the forehand, and they are taking the ball earlier.

"With a two-handed backhand, you can handle a high, heavy ball or a fast return a little easier. The shot is also a lot more effective against the serve." "The one-hander also takes longer to develop. For a young

player, you need strength, timing and very good movement to execute it consistently. Coaches understandably look at the two-hander as the safer and quicker option to teach," Bopanna told Sportstar.

Dr Jack Groppe, former chairman of the United States Tennis Association's National Sports Science Committee, analysed the biomechanics of both shots for his dissertation in the late 1970s.

In his findings published in *The New York Times*, Groppe observed that while the two-hander required synergy between the hips, legs, trunk and arms, the one-hander demanded coordination between the hips, legs, trunk, upper arm, forearm and hand.

In other words, the former is easier to master.

Federer shared similar thoughts while speaking at the US Open pre-tournament press conference, shortly after being inducted into the International Tennis Hall of Fame.

"One of my kids is switching from a double-hander to a one-hander, and I see how hard it is for him to hit it and control it. Eventually you get control, but it takes time. Nowadays, players don't have time.

"During my time, it was 80 per cent net play and 20 per cent baseline. Now it's 90 per cent baseline. The one-hander used to be an advantage; it seems that's not naturally the case anymore," Federer said.

Balachandran Mannikath, director of the Rohan Bopanna Tennis Academy, also pointed to changes in court surfaces and the balls used today, which have added to the challenges. "Nowadays, courts have become slower and balls have become heavier, which has only made things more difficult for the one-hander.

"Earlier, there used to be a lengthier grass-court season and the game used to be more fast-paced. But now, quick points have given way to long rallies," Balachandran explained in a conversation with *Sportstar*. "Even at my academy, most kids are taught how to play with a double-handed backhand. The kids who want to learn the single-hander